Central India depicted a throne, with the trunk of the Bodhi tree behind, surrounded by an open-pillared pavilion. This was labelled in the Brahmi script: 'Bodhi tree of the blessed Sakya Muni', or 'Bhagavato Saka Munino Bodhi'.[13] Since the throne ('vajrasana') is so realistically depicted at Bharhut, it seems likely that the pavilion-like temple was also a faithful image. Which is why the art historian Ananda Coomaraswamy took this to be 'the representation of the one, asserted by tradition, very probably correctly, to have been erected by Asoka at Bodh Gaya.'[14] The tradition which remembered the temple as having been built by Ashoka figures in a fair number of texts. The *Divyavadana* refers to Ashoka having built a chaitya at Bodh Gaya as also at Lumbini, Sarnath, and Kushinagara.[15] Mahabodhi's seventh century CE Chinese visitor Xuanzang says Ashoka had surrounded the Bodhi tree with a nearly three metres high stone wall.[16] A Burmese record of repair of the eleventh century CE says that 'King Dhamma Asoka' built a temple on the spot where Buddha took a meal.[17] The throne itself is an enormous carved seat made up of two horizontal slabs. The lower one is highly polished while the upper has designs on all four sides of honeysuckle motifs; on one side, these alternate with those of geese. The carving is very similar to those on some Ashokan pillars (a further category of monumental sculpture). Considering the quality of the sculpture, the polish, and the massiveness of the throne, this was likely to have been a royal commemorative gift.

In the ensuing years the emperor provided vivid glimpses of other places of Buddhist sanctity by inscribing his presence at them. We meet him at Nigali Sagar (or Niglihawa) in the Nepal terai, some four years after his Sambodhi visit. This is in the Kapilavastu district and gets its name from a large artificial pool in its vicinity, the 'Nigali Sagar'. The focus on an epigraph here was a stupa dedicated to the Buddha Konakamana (or Kanakmuni): Ashoka expanded and rebuilt it in the fourteenth year after his consecration. Buddhists believed Konakamana to be twenty-third in the list